

myself substituting the word *promising* for *small*, and \$8,000 for the actual \$10,143.15. That I couldn't face the full amount is understandable in hindsight. After all those weeks of careful research, the plunking down of \$10,143.15 for an unknown company with an unknown product as recommended by a unknown advisor from Philadelphia was more than this sensible person could bear. For some reason, the plunking down of \$8,000 was acceptable to my subconscious, and dropping \$2,143.15 from the story enabled me to tell it.

When I received the confirmation of my purchase in the mail, I was shocked that \$453.80 had gone for the commission. That this \$453.80 disturbed me even more than the \$10,143.15 purchase itself was a third curious reaction. Then again, I'd watched Ms. Garrett put through the order, which took five seconds or so at her end and amounted to her writing down the letters *ATSI* on a piece of paper and walking the paper to the order desk. Perhaps it's a mistake to let customers witness this process and then send them the bill for it so soon.

After learning of the \$453.80, I called up Ms. Garrett again and brought up the subject of commissions as tactfully as possible. "This couldn't be right, could it?" I asked her. She patiently explained that: (1) she personally gets only a percentage of the percentage, (2) brokerage firms charge higher commissions for over-the-counter-stocks, such as Angstrom, than for stocks listed on the New York Stock Exchange, and (3) she'd gotten me the Prudential-Bache preferential rate even though I was a new customer and technically wasn't entitled to it.

This speech shut me up immediately. Her point 3 made me feel guilty that I'd mentioned anything at all, and I tried to repair the damage to our relationship by voluntarily declaring, "if a person has to worry about commissions, then he shouldn't be buying stocks in the first place." She seemed to agree with this.

If I'd learned anything from this experience, it is my Useful Tip Number Ten:

Never buy a stock whose name you forget without considering the commission
